Makhzin

(selected texts)

edited by Mirene Arsanios, Ziad Dallal and Salma Shamel

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this reader features a selection of texts from the newest issue of Makhzin entitled "Counterlexicons" which was published in January 2024. To read more of the magazine, visit: www.makhzin.org/issues

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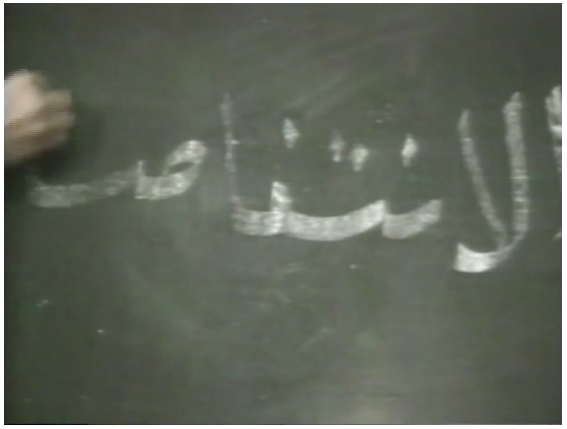
about Makhzin

Launched in Beirut in 2014, Makhzin is a bi-lingual (English/Arabic) magazine dedicated to new and cross-genre writing, including prose, poetry, essays, and occasional translations. Makhzin publishes texts based on an annual open call and on commissions. In parallel with each issue, and running throughout the year, Makhzin commissions and publishes long-form interviews between writers, filmmakers, theorists, translators, and others.
They can be reached at the following email address: magazine@makhzin.org.



Introduction to the End of an Argument, Jayce Salloum and Elia Suleiman, 1990, still

There are two ways to lose oneself: walled segregation in the particular or dilution in the universal. Aimé Césaire

Every attempt at reiterating the magnitude of the loss, degradation, and genocidal violence endured by Palestinians comes with the repressed hope that those perverted by imperialist propaganda will finally come to their senses and reckon with the truth, acknowledge that victims can in turn become perpetrators, or that the weaponization of a collective identity, once marginalized and abused, is now the perverse vehicle of Imperial violence. Some will argue that if all this destruction hasn't yet pierced through the buffer zone shielding their sense of normalcy from the ongoing catastrophe, then nothing, no language, no matter how often repeated, will. While we understand that repetition can risk exiling language to the world of surplus, we also believe that it can serve a different purpose. Language and its performative powers are inherently unpredictable.

Much has been written about the power, or inversely, the powerlessness of language when measured against the killing of a people, against repetitive, structural violence. Adding language to a field of ongoing massacres ("there are no words") or adding it to a field of surplus ("all has been said") devolves discourse into a state of stasis. It turns anger into mute spectatorship and solidarity into apocalyptic antipolitics. Even when uncompromising political pessimism can seem justified, we must insist on the distinction between the importance of creating a language that can grasp the repeated horror "Israel" subjects Palestinians to and the transhistorical claim that everything is the same, all has been said, that language is now dead. We must reiterate the truth beyond binaries of success and defeat; repeat it until abstract universals turn concrete.

The deluge of articles, essays, and political analyses written and published (when not censored) since the beginning of the genocide are indispensable to fighting the war and propaganda machine set forth in full force to defend settler colonial and imperial interests. This 4th issue of Makhzin reflects on both the ludicrous yet necessary tool that is language, its role in making the real more real, in sharpening our politics via a syntax that is lived, enacted, defiantly voiced, and decisively mobilizing.

[...]

No more civilians

by Abou Farman

There are no more civilians.

When the President of Israel says, "this rhetoric about civilians being not aware, not involved, it's absolutely not true, they could have risen up, they could have fought against the evil regime which took over Gaza…" it means there are no civilians.

There are no civilians when the Defense Minister of Israel says, "we are fighting human animals and we act accordingly," and their Ambassador to Germany says, "we will move from containment to eradication."

When there are hostages there are no more civilians.

There are no civilians when 2.5 million hostages are fenced in a space the size of Philadelphia.

There are no civilians when a state controls water, fuel and electricity for 2.5 million people caged in a space the size of Philadelphia, and the Defense Minister of the state declares, "There will be no electricity, no food, no water, no fuel. Everything will be closed." And so everything was closed, there was no water, no electricity, no fuel, no water. There were no civilians.

There are no civilians when 700,000 illegal settlers carry out 3 armed attacks every single day torching cars, homes, orchards, supermarkets, killing and injuring people in the West Bank, and Israel's security forces of occupation intervene by killing another 179 Palestinians including journalists for good measure.

When armed service is mandatory for every citizen there are no civilians.

When Christian evangelicals cheer on the apocalypse, there are no more civilians.

And when Israeli citizens block humanitarian aid for Palestinians starving

in Gaza and 2/3 of all Israeli citizens say that no Palestinians whatsoever should receive humanitarian aid at all, who are the civilians?

When 60 million global viewers tune into the Formula 1 Grand Prix in oil-rich Azerbaijan while the regime is carrying out another genocide, another genocide of Armenians, that is, in Artsakh - with arms provided by Israel, where are the civilians?

When $10 billion of the oil from that oil-rich genocidal state is bought by Israel, Italy, Germany, to fuel their cars, their tanks, their airplanes and to warm their homes – there are no civilians.

When arms, bombs, and planes from Lockheed Martin and Boeing are used on 2.5 million hostages fenced in a space the size of Philadelphia, there are no civilians.

When we fly in Boeing airliners and when Lockheed Martin employs 116,000 people across the US, with 60,000 engineers and scientists drawn from more than 60 partner universities – MIT, Rutgers, UC Santa Barbara, University of Virginia, University of Illinois, Purdue… when there is a student pipeline to bombmakers there are no more civilians.

Where are the civilians when Citibank analysts call the Israel-Hamas war a positive catalyst and the price of Shell oil jumps and the WSJ says Dow Closes Higher as Israel-Hamas War Rattles Markets and capital leaks into our veins…?

…and when the owners and financiers of it all sit on the boards of MoMA and NYU and Whitney and all those places of high art and higher learning, who are the civilians?

When billionaires withdraw their money when someone says Free Palestine there are no civilians.

When NYPD has offices in Tel Aviv and officers are taken to the West Bank to watch Israeli forces in action, when US riot police use Israeli tactics to attack peaceful BLM protestors, and when Apple and Google disable mapping functions on the request of the Israeli Defense Forces there are no more civilians.

There are no civilians

When I breathe and when I can't breathe, when I drive and when I eat, when I heat my home, take a plane, go to university, pay my taxes and get a pension fund, when I open my MacBook Air and get on to Google, when I live, and say Palestine, if I am killed, if I am taken hostage, if I am bombed, if I am stabbed, rammed, cuffed, charged, doxxed, fired, when I die… don't call me a civilian.

Read at the Poets for a Free Palestine event at Poetry Project, Oct 26, 2023.

When I wrote and performed this piece, it felt like a visceral statement surging out of the urgency of the moment. But behind it lay a few years of thinking, teaching and talking about sovereignty, imperialism, sacrifice, killing, genocide, terrorism. The editors of Makhzin rightly urged me to contextualize the piece more and I am doing so here using some material from a talk at a conference in Ramallah in 2015[1]. I am writing as I receive horrific images of the most recent attacks on Tal as-Sultan and Jabalia camps. The public comments on the BBC and Yahoo! News feeds are equally horrific: the relentless claim by a Western audience that this was deserved or that it was Hamas' fault for using 'civilian shields.' According to these comfortable civilian commentators, there are no civilians left. Just shields that have to be broken through.

My interest has been in the non-innocence of the Western civilian and the limitations of the category by which the international community justifies state violence. My disassembling of the category strikes many of my friends and colleagues as a terrible idea. A human rights activist and friend said, "We have to hold on to some distinctions or else we don't have anything." From a strictly legal perspective it may be helpful. For example, even if the category of genocide is not dependent on the notion of the civilian (it depends rather on various configurations of a collective identity), it certainly has helped the ICJ make its case against Israel. But legal language is clearly not enough and at any rate is inseparable from the surrounding moral and political context[2].

The civilian is usually defined not in itself but by virtue of a distinction with soldier or combatant, whose intention is to participate in war and therefore be prepared to kill or be killed. By contrast the non-combatant is assumed innocent and it is precisely the underlying assumption of innocence that is mobilized or broken down when war and killing are justified.

It was not until the 1949 Geneva Convention Relative to the Protection of Civilian Persons in Time of War (IV Geneva Convention) that 'the civilian' formally became a subject of treaty law. And it was only in 1977, in the Protocols Additional to the 1949 Geneva Conventions, that the concept of 'civilian' was actually defined within international law[3]. But the roots take us farther back. It was inextricably tied to the rise of the notion of civilization, meaning that it was tied to colonial conquest and the rise of Just War theories to regulate intra-European animosity and immunity, whilst leaving the colonies outside of the law of nations, where there was neither peace nor law. The latter, in other words, was the realm of barbarism, whereas the former (Europe) was the realm of the rule of law, or of civilization.

The 20th century legal enshrinement of the distinction between civilian and soldier – known as the Principle of Distinction and understood to be the basis of humanitarian law[4] – emerged at a time when that distinction was clearly no longer tenable thanks largely to the actions of the very signatories – "the high contracting parties" – of the very conventions that enshrined the principle[5]. Since World War II, vastly more civilians than military personnel have perished in wars conducted by sovereign states, the figures ranging somewhere between 90% and 60% in the most conservative estimates[6]. In wars led by the United States since the 1950s, millions of civilians have been killed – that is not counting the more than 300,000 killed in the firebombings and nuclear bombings of Japanese cities. Here are the numbers for the top three up to 2013[7]:

Korea: estimates go up to 900,000 in the south and 1 million in the north
Vietnam: some estimates put the civilian toll at 3 million[8] Iraq: from 150,000 according to IBC, but most suggest 2 to 5 times that as probable estimate[9].The more recent of the unending Wars on Terror, initiated by the imperial forces of North America and Europe and continued by other proxies in Syria and Yemen, have resulted in over a 1.2 million direct and indirect deaths.[10]
It is never easy to determine the counterfactuals, but I am not sure how

much extra killing the legal enshrinement of the category of civilian has prevented. Regardless, the several million people that have already been killed in late imperial wars despite the existence of the category are obviously several million too many.

In many ways, Israel's wars echo the War on Terror, launched against 'terrorists,' that is, people who supposedly cannot or do not respect the difference between civilian and other targets, between innocents and other kinds of humans. This is in large part how terrorism is defined: "The organised use of violence to attack non-combatants ("innocents" in a special sense) or their property for political purposes."[11] This invocation of the distinction between people who can and who cannot abide by the principle of distinction is followed immediately by the blurring of the distinction on the part of those who make it. Indeed, it is precisely by blurring it that the conduct of their wars has been justified. Retaining the principle of distinction for the homeland front, imperial warmongers create zones of indistinction elsewhere, where everyone becomes a valid target. The millions killed don't matter because their civilian innocence may not be assumed. The War on Terror is conducted against people who are said to not know the value of life or who simply do not value life like Americans or Europeans, like civilized people. Over and over again, US officials and media asserted this. President Bush repeated variations of the following lines for several years, traveling from Bangor to Flagstaff: "My most important job is to protect American life, to protect innocent life. I mention that because you've got to know something about these people we fight. Unlike us, they don't value life. See, we think every life is precious. Everybody counts."[12] George W. Netanyahu.

While reflecting on the numbers of civilians killed in American imperial wars, note the seamless continuity in Bush's words between innocent life and American life. The American chorus was relentless and is well-known but here is a similar reminder from Staff Sergeant Time Carter from 2008: "… there is no way to tell if he is a civilian or al-Qaida. Here a kid can run up to you to shake your hand and then later throw a grenade at you." Simply put, there are no innocents here, not even the epitome of innocence, The Kid.[13] That kid, of course, was in part invented in Palestine – carrying a stone… but also has an internal version within the United States, where black children like Tamir Rice waving around a toy are shot by the police for waving around what could not

have been assumed to have been a toy. What could not have been assumed, of course, has nothing to do with the object waved around. What could not have been assumed is the innocence of the black child. See also Emmett Till. This was the foundation of both lynching and of the carceral state –– white nationalist bloodlust got absorbed by the apparatus of the state, anonymized, institutionalized, legalized, proceduralized as a way of protecting sovereignty from its constitutive violence: "We the white people·"

In the reversals and refusals of that original text, I felt the need to question the civilian status of non-combatants in the West. I needed to challenge the assumed innocence of liberal democratic power, that is, the innocence of the peaceful, rational citizens that are said to constitute it. That includes many of us who are enrolled in the political economy and social lives of Western institutions, where – to take one clear example – those institutions benefit from and invest in companies like Boeing that make 'civilian aircraft' as well as GBU-39 bombs used to burn Tal al-Sultan camp. That is partly what we mean when in protests we charge companies, investors, CEOs, University Presidents, and so on with complicity: "Mr/s civilian, you can't hide, we charge you with genocide."

1. Thanks go to Tonya Foster, and Miriam Ticktin for helpful comments.
2. Ticktin, Miriam. 2020. "Innocence: Shaping the Concept and Practice of Humanity." In Human Rights and Humanitarianism: Between Palliation and Transformation, ed. Michael Barnett; Cambridge University Press. Pp. 185-202.
3. For a thorough study of these links see Kinsella, Helen. 2011. The Image before the Weapon: a critical history of the distinction between combatant and civilian. Cornell University Press. Much of my account in this section relies on this book.
4. Protocol Additional to the Geneva Conventions of 12 August 1949, and relating to the Protection of Victims of International Armed Conflicts (Protocol I), 8 June 1977. The ICRC Also see: https://www.geneva-academy.ch/RULAC/international_humanitarian_law.php.
5. Kinsella, op cit.
6. For a conservative take on the disputes and the numbers see Roberts 2010. He seems to think somehow that lowering the ratio to 60% makes the whole scenario morally more acceptable.
7. That is not counting Afghanistan, Cambodia or any of the proxy wars. For a comparison see, Kiernan, Ben. Roots of U.S. Troubles in Afghanistan: Civilian Bombing Casualties and the Cambodian Precedent. The Asia Pacific Journal. Volume 8, Issue 26, Number 4.
8. Conway-Lanz, Sahr. 2006. Collateral Damage: Americans, Noncombatant Immunity, and Atrocity after World War II. NY: Routledge.
9. Iraq Body Count has the conservative: numbers ; high estimates have come from the: Lancet
10. https://caat.org.uk/homepage/stop-arming-saudi-arabia/the-war-on-yemens-civilians/
    https://www.globalr2p.org/countries/syria/
11. C. A. J. Coady. 2004. Terrorism and Innocence. The Journal of Ethics, Vol. 8, No. 1, Terrorism (2004), pp. 37-58. For a different definition and history of the term see Palmer-Fernandez, Gabriel. 2005. Terrorism, Innocence, and Justice. Philosophy & public policy quarterly. Volume 25. Issue 3. Page 22 - 27.
12. http://www.presidency.ucsb.edu/ws/?pid=15
    Also see: https://freerepublic.com/focus/news/762820/posts
13. Also see Faulkner, Joanne. 2008. The Innocence of Victimhood Versus the "Innocence of Becoming": Nietzsche, 9/11, and the "Falling Man". The Journal of Nietzsche Studies. Issue 35/36, Spring/Autumn 2008, Pp. 67-85.

This is A Long Drive For Someone With Nothing to Think About

by Nora Treatbaby

Beautiful and boring. Integrated in my head as a voiceless stream of environment, separate from myself completely. North to south and south to north. Between a river and a border like everything else. Every week I drive up and down the Taconic State Parkway from New York City to Hudson and back. Its soft curves make way for vistas of the Hudson Highlands. As the Bronx becomes exurb commuter communities, gas stations become predominant, and then a forest makes way for trees. Straight up farms up in there too. This is probably not the space to draw out every single social and economic dimension of my drive like the fact that the Parkway was the result of the last great era of 20th century American social programs designed by people who had to elevate the landscape towards a sense of myth around its emptiness and grandeur as the Yeoman farmer of the previous centuries began dying out as the productive capacity switched towards an industrial manufacturing capitalist economy to produce for example the automobile whose invention was necessitated by the imperative to revolutionize transportation so as to make the capacity to exchange things adequate to our ability to make things. They built this road for people to travel to the newly minted State Park system, to ascend the shoulder of the hills and look out over the green green valley. I often think about how much of the Earth's surface is covered in concrete, and how long that will last. I'm in my Subaru Impreza listening to podcasts and I try not to notice my surroundings, the dull act of commuting deadens whatever psychedelic flares of trees and road signs and speed and skies are mixing into reality, now. There is a world out there, latent with historical processes, determining my experience—and my experience is still in all the waning possibility of love as we know it, full of the single miracle that is a ribbon of light, dancing for a moment in my windshield with all the specificity of nothing, breaking the spell of the present's withdrawal. And I am snapped back into place, at a distance from beauty. It has been removed from me by the effects of history, placed before me by the sun. Maybe the kernel of rebellion is just that exact distance and it does not matter the manifold pleasures and distractions available to us; just as long as we are human there remains inevitably a concern for what is lovely and I believe that the Taconic State Parkway is not because it carries me between an apartment

I can barely afford to a job I can barely afford. It's really not its fault, and I like the view but existence is complicated. What is taken from us expressed in the car, the landscape, the food, the gas, the weather, and the light outpaces the promise of safety. I feel a little bit lonely and desperate all the time. Which is all to say there really is no such thing as banality. The violence expressed here is by significant orders of magnitude different than that experienced in other places in the world but threaded by the same ordering mechanisms and so when I look out my window at my world and see the cost of millions of ruined lives all along different points of the chain empire must cannibalize in order that there just be this many gas stations I become replete with my motive force to change our world to something resembling something we don't yet know about, or something that could have been, has been, and so could be later. One need not wait for exposure to the crisis but rather sit up in your car and look around and measure what is available to you in terms such as power or beauty. I think I'm good on the false equivalence of difference. Boredom is a symptom of disconnection so maybe it's the living that's mundane and not the life.

See No Evil

by Wendy Lotterman

They did this to us, but then we kept doing it,
Too. Moved by more than continuity, the song
Loops too fast to get off, a teacup at the carnival
In mid-eighties amusement, a national distraction
From bad appetites and statecraft. Math falters
At the door to a militant paternal ear-drum,
Then re-enters with the tutor on the eve of
A very big retrieval. In the video, everyone is
Instructed to say their name and yours. Love
Adds an inch and a year to your life. You held
Guns in a battlefield, and I shot trash at Jewish
Summer-camp. The family home bursts for
The holiday, a map of sleeping bodies laid out
Across the ottomans. Awake more than usual,
Conjugated by mood, I search all the bedrooms,
And I beg you, passionately, to be with me in
The insanity of balancing all this effort on a choice.
Traffic enacts a contrast with the messages
Coming into your lap. The event, in its prolific
Sensibility, asks why it is so difficult to share;
Why kids can multiply, freely, in love, but not us;
And is this voluntary intolerance, this failure to
Learn infinity from children, the reason we keep
Pushing the commune in Nesodden deeper
Into fiction. You are far; you are conquered in
A car seat. In the rush for immediacy, I wish to
Download this background as sacrament, and
Dissolve it on your tongue at the swim club.
Currency never invented anything. But all that
Cash on the table did something, dilating the room,
Dialing up the volume of possibility, so that
By the time I left, I couldn't hear much else,
Or fully get back from the house.

ما لم يتبقَّ لأحد – تعقيب

راجي بطحيش

لم أكتب شيئا يستحقّ القراءة أو النشر منذ الثامن من أكتوبر،أي منذ بدأت حرب الإبادة، لقد فقدتُ ترف التجريب والانتهاك، ونبش تربة المسلّمات الوطنية والجندرية والجسدية، ثمّة نكسة خطيرة تتمثل في العودة القسرية للتلويح بالرموز الأولى، التي كانت تبدو وقد انقضى وقتها وأصبحت بالية وفولكلورية، لكنّ حرب البقاء تحمل قوانين تخصّها هي، فلا وقت للكتابة الكويرية...

باتت غزة هي نقطة القياس وهي الحقيقة ، الحقيقة التي تتربص بي وتزحف نحوي/نا لتفيدنا بالأخبار العاجلة..وأنت تحتسي القهوة في المقهى الأنيق تمّ تدمير مربّع سكني في جباليا أو خان يونس وقُتل جرّاء ذلك تسعون شخصًا بينهم نساء وأطفال، سقطوا كجبال اللحم في دقائق ..وأنت تتمشى مع كلبتك على الشاطئ تتأمل أجساد الرجال الإسرائيليين شبه العراة وهم يتشمّسون أو يتدرّبون لتعزيز كتلهم العضلية وتحاول معالجة التضارب الغرائزي في رأسك، تتساقط الأجساد الغزّية واحد تلوَ الآخر وهي تفرّ من الشمال إلى الوسط، أو من الوسط إلى الجنوب أو من الجنوب إلى جهنم، وذلك بفعل القنص أو وقاحة الحقيقة. كأني أعيش في فيلم سينمائي من فئة تيّار الوعي، حيث ينفصل وعي البطل المشبع بالكراهية، الحقد والرغبة بالانتقام والتشفي، عن شريط الصوت والتكوين البصري.

عن ماذا أكتب؟ عن المعتقلين الذين يتكدّسون أمام العدسات بملابسهم الداخلية..عن جماليات أجسادهم، عن تنوّعها، مِن مَن نحت الشقاء جسده ومَن نحتت معاهد اللياقة محاكاة لجسد يبتغيه؟ عن أنواع السراويل الداخلية التي يفضّلها الغزّيون...البوكسر أم السليبر الضيقة أم البيضاء القطنية التي تصل حتى الركبة وهي التي عادة ما يرتديها البالغون مثلي ..أي من تجاوزوا الخمسين...عن ماذا أكتب؟ لماذا يحظى الغزّيون بشعر قليل على أبدانهم، بينما يكتسي رجال الشمال وخاصّة القريبون من الحدود مع لبنان بالشعر الغزير وخاصّة على ظهورهم.

هل أكتب نصوصًا تفكيكية تعارك الفكر المتكلّس، صرنا خبيرين بالتفكيك، تفكيك الأجساد وتحويلها إلى أشلاء، أمٌّ تحمل أشلاء أطفالها في كيس مبقّع بالدم وأبٌ ينتحب ويُحسِن قرب أشلاء عائلته، هذا رأس ابنتي المتمرّدة وهذا ذراع ولدي ذو الملامح الأنثوية وهذه خاصرة ابنتي التي تفضّل لاكان على فرويد وتجهّز أطروحة عن نظريات بودريار في الإرهاب.

أعتقد أنّ ما تبقّى لي هو الانتظار، تمرير الوقت، هكذا لإحصاء الخسائر لأرى هل فقدتُ قدرتي على التغريد خارج السرب وإحداث الصدمات الأدبية أم أنّ "حشيشتي أنطفأت " وبالفعل تحقّق وصف أمّي لي كما ذكرتُ قبل عشر سنوات..."راجي طالع كتير فلسطيني" ...ماتت أمّي بعدها بعامين وخوفي أن يكون وصفها قد تحقّق الآن، أي أن أكون قد فقدت ترف الانتهاك بفعل العمر أو تأثير فكرة الإبادة.

All that's Left to No-one (Afterword)

by Raji Bathish

Translated from Arabic by Suneela Mubayi

I have not written anything worth publishing since the 8th of October. Since the beginning of this genocidal war, I have lost the luxury of experimenting and transgressing, of digging up the dirt under everything we don't dare to question, all the truths we hold to be self-evident when it comes to the homeland, to gender norms, to the body. There is a serious setback embodied in this forced return to brandishing the fundamental symbols, the ones that we thought had become outdated and irrelevant to the point of becoming part of folklore. But this latest war of survival has its own rules of engagement, and there is no longer any time for queer writing.

Gaza has become the ultimate reference point on which to measure everything. It is now the ultimate Truth lying in wait to ambush me, creeping towards me/us to give us the breaking news. As you sip your coffee in some chic cafe, an entire residential block in Jabaliya or Khan Younis is destroyed, and as a result, ninety people are killed, among them women and children, who collapsed like an avalanche of flesh in mere minutes. As you walk your dog on the beach, you look at the semi-naked bodies of Israeli men sunbathing or exercising to strengthen their muscle mass and try to deal with the clashing primal urges inside your head. Gazan bodies topple one after another as they flee from the north of the strip to the center, from the center to the south, or from the south to Hell, through being sniped or just by the sheer shamelessness of the Truth. It feels like I'm living in a stream-of-consciousness movie, where the consciousness of the main character, who is saturated with hate, malice, and a thirst for vengeance and retribution, is dissociated from the audio track and visual reel.

What should I write about? About the detainees piled up in front of cameras in their underwear? About the aesthetics of their bodies in all their diversity, ranging from those whose bodies have been sculpted by hardship to those who have sculpted their bodies in fitness centers to mimic a body they want for themselves? About the kinds of underwear that Gazan men prefer? Boxers, Speedo-style tighties, or the white cotton trunks that reach to the knee, usually

worn by older men like me (the ones over fifty)? What should I write about? Why guys from Gaza get to have less hairy bodies, whereas men in the north, especially those close to the Lebanese border are covered in hair, especially on their backs?

Should I write deconstructive texts that fight against ossified ways of thinking? We've really become experts at deconstructing: deconstructing bodies and transforming them into dissociated limbs. A mother carries her children's dismembered body parts in a blood-stained bag. A father wails in grief near the body parts of his family, repeatedly uttering *hasbi allah wa ni'm al–wakil*, entrusting God to take care of things for him. Here is the head of my rebellious daughter, he says, and there is the arm of my effeminate-looking son, and here is the waist of my daughter who preferred Lacan over Freud; she was writing a thesis on Baudrillard's theories of terrorism.

I think that what's left to me is to wait. To pass the time like this, to count the losses, to see whether I have lost my ability to wander outside the pack and create literary shocks. Or have I lost my mojo? Has what my mother said about me ten years ago - that I came out too Palestinian - actually come true? My mom died two years later, and I'm afraid that she may have been proven right, that I've come out too Palestinian for my own good and have lost the luxury of transgressing boundaries, either as a result of aging or from the impact of the thought of this genocide.

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...have ...word reading group

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